The passive voice (all tenses)

Understand it

In an active sentence the subject does the action: Farmers grow rice. In a passive sentence the subject receives it: Rice is grown. We use the passive when the action matters more than who does it, which is exactly what processes, maps and science texts need.

Only the verb be changes with the tense; the main verb is always the past participle. Learn the irregular participles you need for processes.

The rules

- Form: be + past participle (the verb be changes with the tense).
- Present simple: Water is heated. Past simple: Water was heated. Present perfect: Water has been heated. Future: Water will be heated. Modal: Water can be heated.
- Use the passive when the doer is not important or not known: Cars are produced in Japan.
- Add the doer with by only when it is important: The report was written by experts.

All the words and forms you need

All tenses	is done · is being done · was done · was being done · has been done · had been done · will be done · is going to be done · can / must / should be done
Process verbs (regular)	collected · heated · cooled · mixed · filtered · stored · transported · packaged · delivered · recycled · processed
Process verbs (irregular)	made · built · cut · put · sent · taken · ground · fed · grown · sold · thrown away
Sequence	First, · Next, · Then, · After that, · Following this, · Once ... has been ..., · Finally, · In the final stage,
Map changes	was replaced by · was demolished · was converted into · was extended · was relocated · were constructed

Where you use it

Writing: Task 1 processes: The leaves are collected, then they are washed and dried. Maps: A new road was built.

Speaking: Describing how something is made: First the milk is heated, then ...

Reading: Texts often use the passive; the subject of the sentence may not be the doer.

More examples

- First, the cocoa beans are harvested and dried in the sun.
- Once the glass has been sorted, it is crushed and melted.

- The old factory was demolished and replaced by a park.
- The bottles are being collected right now.
- New houses will be built along the river.
- The milk must be kept cold.

Common mistakes

WRONG	RIGHT
✗ The cotton is grow in India.	✓ The cotton is grown in India.
✗ The road built last year.	✓ The road was built last year.
✗ The bottles are wash then fill.	✓ The bottles are washed and then filled.

Speaking practice: answer using this grammar

1. How is bread made? Describe the steps.
2. What has been built in your town recently?
3. How are rubbish and recycling collected where you live?
4. Which famous building in your country was built long ago?
5. How is your favorite dish prepared?

Writing practice

Describe how paper is recycled in 5 passive sentences (collect, sort, wash, press, dry).

Practice

1. Make passive: People grow rice in Asia.

2. Make passive: They built the bridge in 1990.

3. Make passive: Workers will clean the machines.

4. Make passive: Someone has stolen my bag.

5. Complete: Plastic ___ (recycle) every day in our city.

6. Correct: The eggs are collect by hand.

Answers

1. Rice is grown in Asia.
2. The bridge was built in 1990.
3. The machines will be cleaned.
4. My bag has been stolen.
5. is recycled
6. The eggs are collected by hand.